CHAPTER THREE

WEB OF INTRIGUE

The Triskelion dominates the Washington, D.C., skyline, rising from the Potomac River to tower ominously over the centers of government and justice. S.H.I.E.L.D.'s headquarters is home not just to operations and advanced science but also to the slippery moral ambiguity of classified methods and secrets. Intelligence comes at a high price—maybe too high—and all may not be as it seems on this island of deceit.

In the comic-book Marvel Universe, the Triskelion is in New York. But for the movie, it exists on Theodore Roosevelt Island, a sliver of National Park Service land sandwiched between the neighborhood of Georgetown and the city of Arlington, Virginia. The actual site has been a park since Steve Rogers was a boy.

"The Triskelion isn't real, but we wanted a real landmass to build our imaginary building on top of," Co-producer Nate Moore explains.

The three-branched form of a triskelion is evident in the comic-book version's architecture, but that wasn't realistic given Roosevelt Island's long, narrow shape.

"One of the very important things to me and the directors was to ground everything in the film and base it in a true reality—a reality where you can believe there is a building of this size on Roosevelt Island," Production Designer Peter Wenham says. "We built the Triskelion to straddle the existing bridge that crosses Roosevelt Island. It was also enormously important to me to have something representative of a triskelion. And in the film, if you see a top shot looking at the main tower block, although it's round, there are three sides to it that actually form the shape of a triskelion."